Repetition and Beginning, Middle, End

By Phil Kaye

Repetition

My mother taught me this trick
If you repeat something over and over again it loses its
    meaning
For example:
Homework, homework, homework, homework,
    homework, homework, homework, homework,
See, nothing

Our existence, she said, is the same way.
You watch the sun set too often, it just becomes 6 PM
You make the same mistake over and over; you'll stop
    calling it a mistake
If you just
wake up, wake up, wake up, wake up, wake up.
one day you'll forget why
Nothing is forever, she said.

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INTRODUCTION

Words shape our thinking, trigger emotions and affect our behavior. Words are power. No one knows this better than poet Phil Kaye who, at a very young age, struggled to use his words during his parents' divorce. He developed a stutter that has challenged him to this day. But the power of words has set him free.

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My parents left each other when I was 7 years old
Before their last argument they sent me off to the
    neighbor's house,
like some astronaut jettisoned from the shuttle.
When I came back there was no gravity in our home, beds
floating
I imagined it as an accident, that when I left
They whispered to each other "I love you" so many times
    they forgot what it meant
Family, family, family, family, family, family

My mother taught me this trick
If you repeat something over and over again it loses its
    meaning
This became my favorite game

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It made the sting of words evaporate.

Separation, separation, separation;

see, nothing

Apart, apart, apart;

see, nothing

I am an injured handyman now

I work with words all day

Shut up, I know the irony!

When I was young, I was taught that the trick to dominating language

was breaking it down

Convincing it that it was worthless

I love you, I love you, I love you, I love you;

See, nothing

Soon after my parents' divorce, I developed a stutter

Fate is a cruel and efficient tutor

There is no escape in stutter

You feel the meaning of every word drag itself up your throat

S-s-s-separation

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Stutter is a cage made of mirrors

Every "Are you ok?"

Every "What'd you say?"

Every "Come on kid, spit it out"

Is a glaring reflection you cannot escape

Every terrible moment skips upon its own announcement

Over and over until it just hangs there,

floating in the middle of the room

Mom, Dad,

I am not wasteful with my words anymore.

Even now after hundreds of hours of practicing away my stutter,

I still feel the claw of meaning in the bottom of my throat.

I have heard that even in space;

You can hear the scratching of a

I-I-I-I love you.

AWARD HISTORY

2023 National Qualifier – MS (This poem only)

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TRANSITION

Words are power; and words strung together like pearls create stories. Every person has their own unique story and according to poet Phil Kay: "Every great story has a beginning, middle and ending – not necessarily in that order. We are all great stories."

Beginning, Middle, End

Chapter 389:

The boy, hair still long, fingers still too short, is 98
    years old.
He sits at a restaurant alone.
The stranger next to him is eating something that looks|
    vaguely delicious, so
the boy takes his fork, sticks it in his meal, and takes a
    bite.
He says "I'm 98 years old . . . go ahead, say something,
    asshole."

Chapter 14:

The boy is eight years old; he and his best friend
come up with a great idea for a prank; they are sure
    they will not get caught.
The next morning, every house on his street - except his
    own - has toilet paper on their front lawn.
They get caught.

Chapter 146:

And the boy and the girl live happily ever after.

Chapter 231:

And the boy and the girl vow to never speak to each
    again.

Every great story has a beginning middle and ending -
not necessarily in that order.
We are all great stories, but not all written as chapter
    books.
I know, there are moments not meant to be bound,
that we scribble too much in the margins to read our
    own page numbers.

Like the nights you thought you were invincible,
ran out into the lightning storm with a million keys
    tied to a million kites, and
a clench in your jaw that said, "Take me with you
    goddamnit. I dare you"
And the week you finally reached out to feel your

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father's cheeks
and just found paper cuts.

I know the nights we shatter hourglasses to fall asleep,
the afternoons we take photographs of our own shadows
just to prove that we left a mark.

I know the wetness of your lips.
I know that you are the leaf off of the tree of your
parents' first kiss,
and if you hold your shrubs to the sky, you can see their
veins there.
I know that in later chapters, you will complain
about how things were better back in your day.

Give yourself lots to complain about.

And know that your legs were made to run, your bones
were made to heal,
so let yourself fall so deeply into somebody else that you
do not know
which way is up,
knowing that one day, you may fall out -
know exactly which way is down.

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Call your mother crying as the first day you were born.
"Baby," she will call you. "Baby, it's okay. Every great
story has a beginning, middle, and ending,
not necessarily in that order."

Chapter 189:

The boy, too old now to celebrate his birthdays and too
young to treasure them,
uses his fists.
Punches his own reflection to see if it's real,
breaks his hand into back into the opposite of a fist, a
conch shell of sinew.
He holds it to his ear and can hear the ocean of his own
bloodline.
"Stand up, boy, not just with your legs.
You, be your own story, six hundred words per minute.
You, glasses by age seven.
You, never stopped to read the back cover even though
you know
what happens at the end."

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Chapter 431:

Once upon a time, there was a boy.

He is not here anymore, but the branches he left all
holds their leaves to the sky,

and you can see the outline of his shadow on the
sidewalk.

Chapter 1:

Once upon a time, there was a woman and a man,

and the first night they kissed, a seedling blossomed
from the back of her neck.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier (As a Collection)

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